

THE LAST GOOD YEAR

Written by

J. Okonkwo

FADE IN:

INT. VALLEY PAWN & LOAN - DAY

Fluorescent light. Glass cases of dead men's watches.

MAYA REYES, 34, sets a battered guitar case on the counter. She opens it. A 1962 Gibson ES-335, cherry red, the finish worn through where a thumb has rested for sixty years.

DESMOND, 60s, behind the counter, does not touch it.

DESMOND

That's your grandfather's.

MAYA

It's mine.

DESMOND

I know whose it is. I'm saying I know what it is.

He slides a Rolex Submariner across the glass toward her -- someone else's pawn, tagged and forgotten.

DESMOND (CONT'D)

Man came in with that in '09. Said he'd be back Friday. Seventeen years of Fridays.

MAYA

How much for the guitar.

DESMOND

Not enough. Ask me again tomorrow.

EXT. SUNSET BOULEVARD - CONTINUOUS

Maya walks east, guitar case knocking against her leg. Traffic crawls. Above her, the CHATEAU MARMONT sits behind its hedge like something that got away with it.

She doesn't look up. She's done looking up.

INT. THE GOLDEN BEAR DINER - NIGHT

A counter, eight stools, a jukebox nobody has fed since the Clinton administration.

Maya sits with a COCA-COLA in a glass bottle, sweating onto a napkin. Across from her: RAY LINDQUIST, 40s, a producer who still says "the industry" without irony.

RAY
I can get you a room. Two days.
Nothing fancy.

MAYA
And in exchange.

RAY
You cut "BYE BYE BLACKBIRD." Straight,
no tricks. Ninety seconds. It's for a
car commercial.

MAYA
That song is a hundred years old.

RAY
Which is why it's free. That's the
whole business plan, Maya. I'm not
hiding it from you.

Maya turns the bottle a quarter turn. Then another.

MAYA
And the recording? The one from
'26. The Gene Austin.

RAY
(too quickly)
Different animal. We're not touching
that.

MAYA
No. We're not.

INT. MERIDIAN SOUND - RECORDING BOOTH - DAY

Cramped. Egg-crate foam gone yellow. A NEUMANN U 87 hangs on a boom, the only object in the room worth anything.

Through the glass, an ENGINEER, 20s, watches PRO TOOLS scroll.

Maya plays. It's good. It's better than the room deserves.

RAY (O.S.)
(through talkback)
Again. Warmer.

She plays it again. Warmer.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

One room. A mattress. On the windowsill: a Penguin paperback of THE GREAT GATSBY, spine broken, read to death.

Maya smokes a MARLBORO out the window, which she quit in March and has now unquit.

Her phone buzzes. A text from a number she didn't save:

INSERT - PHONE SCREEN

"saw the session sheet. we need to talk. - E"

BACK TO SCENE

Maya reads it twice. Puts the phone face down.

EXT. VENICE BEACH - BOARDWALK - DAY

Tourists. A man selling sunglasses that are not the brand they claim to be.

ELENA VOSS, 50s, sharp, walks the boardwalk in NIKE running shoes that have actually been run in. Maya struggles to keep pace.

ELENA
Meridian Sound. That's who's paying you.

MAYA
So?

ELENA
There's a Meridian Records in Nashville. Forty years old. Owns a catalog. They are not the same company and Ray knows it.

MAYA
That's not illegal.

ELENA
It's not illegal for you. You're not the one signing the licenses.

INT. VOSS & ASSOCIATES - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Glass table. One legal pad. Elena writes nothing on it.

ELENA
The composition is public domain.
Fine. Nobody disputes that.

MAYA
Then what's the problem.

ELENA
The problem is that Ray's cutting
your vocal over a lift from the 1926
master. He's not licensing it. He's
hoping nobody with a lawyer ever
hears it.

MAYA
That's his exposure. Not mine.

ELENA
Your voice is on it, Maya. When it
lands, it lands on the thing people
can hear.

INT. THE GOLDEN BEAR DINER - NIGHT

Same stool. Different night. Ray is already talking when we
arrive.

RAY
-- and I'm telling you the estate has
never once come after a ninety-second
spot. Not once. You know what those
people at that label are? They're
vultures who bill by the hour and
produce nothing. Parasites with a
mailing address.

MAYA
You want me to say yes because
they're bad people.

RAY
I want you to say yes because you're
out of Fridays.

INT. THE ECHO PLEX - BACKSTAGE - NIGHT

Amps. Cable. A poster for a band that broke up.

A YOUNG MUSICIAN, 22, tunes and talks at the same time.

YOUNG MUSICIAN
My whole thing is I want to be, like,

JONI MITCHELL. But now. Do you know what I mean?

MAYA
I know exactly what you mean.

YOUNG MUSICIAN
Somebody said you almost signed to Meridian.

MAYA
Somebody says a lot of things.

INT. MERIDIAN SOUND - CONTROL ROOM - NIGHT

Ray alone. He pulls up a file. Hits space.

We hear it: Maya's vocal, clean and new, riding on a bed of 1926 shellac hiss. It's beautiful. It's also theft.

Ray closes his eyes. Not with guilt. With satisfaction.

INT. MAYA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Maya listens to the same file on a laptop. Once. Twice.

She opens a browser. Types: "Gene Austin 1926 rights holder."

She reads for a long time.

EXT. VALLEY PAWN & LOAN - DAY

Maya at the door before it opens. Desmond lets her in.

INT. VALLEY PAWN & LOAN - CONTINUOUS

The Gibson is still on the wall. He hasn't sold it.

DESMOND
I told you. Ask me tomorrow.

MAYA
It's tomorrow.

DESMOND
It's been four months.

MAYA
I need it back. I've got a thing to finish and I'd like to finish it on the right instrument.

Desmond takes it down. Doesn't ask for money.

DESMOND

Your grandfather cut a record in
1958. Did you know that? One side.
Never went anywhere.

MAYA

I didn't know that.

DESMOND

Nobody licensed it. Nobody stole it.
It just sat there being his.
(beat)
There's worse outcomes.

INT. VOSS & ASSOCIATES - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

Elena reads a single sheet. Sets it down.

ELENA

You want to release it yourself.

MAYA

The composition's free. I'll cut my
own master. Mine. Nobody's hiss but
mine.

ELENA

It'll be smaller.

MAYA

It'll be mine.

Elena finally writes something on the legal pad.

ELENA

Then let's clear it properly. All of
it. Every last thing in the room.

FADE OUT.

THE END